Secrets

By Walt Vail

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS: *In the words of Samuel Johnson: "We cannot tell the precise moment when friendship is formed. As in filling a vessel drop by drop, there is at last a drop which makes it run over; so, in a series of kindnesses there is at last one which makes the heart run over."*
ACTOR: *Children of domestic violence however have few friends . . . friends share secrets which is the first lesson victims of child abuse learn. Never tell. No matter how hard she tries to deny it, Deidre is in desperate need of a friend.*
ACTRESS: *If only she could trust someone. But she believes that if anyone really knew her, they'd realize what an awful person she is. That's what her Dad told her anyway.*
ACTOR: *Nothing in life is free.*
ACTRESS: *Everything has a price. To have a true friend, I'd have to sacrifice my*
TOGETHER: *Secrets by Walt Vail*

CHARLIE: Deidre.

DIEDRE: Yes? I have to finish this term paper.

CHARLIE: Can I help?

DIEDRE: I'd rather do it myself.

CHARLIE: I like you, Deidre.

DIEDRE: Charlie, I go steady with David.

CHARLIE: Why David?

DIEDRE: He doesn't make unreasonable demands on me.

CHARLIE: And I do? How's your father treating you?

DIEDRE: I'm sorry I told you that, Charlie. It's not your concern. I shouldn't have spoken. *(beat)* My father treats me okay. He's not drinking.

CHARLIE: He'll start up again. Like my old man. Drinks, then starts swinging.

DIEDRE: Your father hits you?

CHARLIE: Not since I got bigger that him.

DIEDRE: I can't hope for that, I guess.

CHARLIE: *(looks closely)* You've got another bruise.

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DIEDRE: I turn black and blue if someone breathes on me.

CHARLIE: He's beating you up all the time. You think I can't see that?

DIEDRE: Please, Charlie. Don't tell anyone!

CHARLIE: I couldn't sleep last night, Deidre. All I could think of was a guy that weighs 180 pounds beating up on a small, defenseless girl. You know what could happen if he hits you too hard?

DIEDRE: I don't want to talk about it.

CHARLIE: *(pause)* You want to pretend it isn't happening?

DIEDRE: It isn't happening. He's been calm. Charlie, my father earns a living for our family. If I make trouble for him, he could lose his job.

CHARLIE: Before your mother died…did he beat her too?

DIEDRE: They had their arguments, like any married couple. In the bedroom at night, I'd hear her cry out, as if she was having a nightmare.

CHARLIE: Deidre, your father is sick.

(As she remembers, D has a flashback. She reverts back to a little girl. D sways back and forth in a rhythmic manner, quietly humming or singing a tune. C changes his stance and attitude into one much older than himself, as C plays D's father)

FATHER: Daddy's songbird be singin'?

DIEDRE: (voice of a child) For Mama. I'm singin' for her. Do ya think she can hear me?

FATHER: Dunno. She barely heard ***me*** when she was alive.

DIEDRE: How is me and Peggy gonna get raised now, without Mama?

FATHER: You'll have to look after Peggy. You're the lady of the house now, Deidre. I'm counting on my little songbird.

DIEDRE: Me? I can't do it like her. I ain't Mama.

FATHER: You're responsible now. There's rent to pay. You do a good job, You got to do a good job, ya hear? Rent's not free no more. Rent's not free.

********Flashback ends*******

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DIEDRE: My father's not sick, exactly. Men have frustrations.

CHARLIE: The heck we do! I'd never hit a woman. And my father may have beat me, but he'd never dare hit my mother. I'd break his head if he ever did.

DIEDRE: I guess that's why I told you, Charlie. I just sensed you'd understand. I wasn't trying to get you angry. When I graduate from high school in two more years, I'll get a job. I'll get a place of my own, and I'll take Peggy with me. I'll be a mother to her.

CHARLIE: How old is Peggy?

DIEDRE: She's eleven.

CHARLIE: When did he first hit you?

DIEDRE: I was *(beat)* eleven. Right after mother died. He was alone. . .

CHARLIE: When you wear out, he'll start on Peggy. A job won't be enough. You need money to go out on your own.

DIEDRE: I know where to get it, if necessary. [My father] has a lot of cash. He doesn't trust banks.

CHARLIE: So, steal it and get out now! He can't say anything. You could turn him in for abuse!

DIEDRE: I can't steal his money!

CHARLIE: He owes it to you! I'll go with you.

DIEDRE: You're not my boyfriend.

CHARLIE: You don't like David. You go with him for convenience because he's stupid and harmless, and he doesn't really care about you. Not like I do! *(beat)* How much has the old man got? Tell me where it is, and I'll steal it for you. Give me the key, and I'll go in while he's working. I'll smash a few windows to make it look like a break in.

DIEDRE: Forget it!

CHARLIE: If I had some of that money—do you know what I'd do? I'd solve this problem for you.

DIEDRE: How much money do you need?

CHARLIE: A thousand dollars. I'll get a place of my own. Then you can join me and bring your sister. Another town, another state. You and Peggy can go to school there, wherever it is. And I'll get a job.

DIEDRE: I'll think about it. Now let me do my schoolwork. I have to be home early today.

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CHARLIE: Something more is bothering you, I can tell. You act like you don't want to be noticed, like you have a secret. I know, because I have my own secrets. I'm like you.

DIEDRE: No one's like me, Charlie. No one.

CHARLIE: Have you ever thought about killing yourself?

DIEDRE: No, I think about surviving. I work hard at staying alive. You mustn't think about killing yourself. God wouldn't like it.

CHARLIE: You believe in God? If there is a God, he's playing a big joke on all of us.

DIEDRE: No, he's just testing us. He gives us the answers, if we recognize them. *(beat)* We all grow up.

CHARLIE: No, we don't. Some of us never make it. Something happens—a car accident, an drug overdose.

DIEDRE: Don't get morbid.

CHARLIE: I think there's something you're not telling me.

DIEDRE: I have plenty of secrets. More than any girl my age should have.

CHARLIE: *(pauses, as D. drifts deeply in thought)* Deidre? Deidre?

********Flashback *******

DIEDRE: *(shielding her sister)* I know it's been a tough day, Daddy. Don't! Come on. Please! You don't need to. There's one more beer left. Maybe if you drink it, you can go to sleep.

FATHER: *(in a rage)* Out of my way, girl! You can go to your room. Daddy is giving you permission to leave. Now get your butt out of here before I stop feeling so generous!

DIEDRE: Take it out on me. It's my fault! Whatever happened, I did it!

FATHER: I spawned a crazy girl. Can't hear nothin'. Now ***move*** before you find yourself sleepin' in the backyard. Rent on this trailer ain't free, ya' know.

DIEDRE: *(tries to hold him back)* I know, Daddy. But you can't. She's only ten. Get out of here, Peggy!!!

FATHER: *(grabs her by the collar)* You can go to your room, or I can EVICT you. Understand!?!

********Flashback Ends *******

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CHARLIE: Deidre…Deidre?

DIEDRE: *(painfully)* I can't promise anything for sure, but…

CHARLIE: Trust me.

DIEDRE: I do. But, we're . . . friends, that's all. I wouldn't want to hurt or upset you. But, I'll get you the money. We have one chance. . . and you're it, Charlie.

CHARLIE: I won't let you down.

DIEDRE: You don't really know me. If you did, you wouldn't like me. I'm not a very nice person. You'll find that out before long, Charlie. Life swallowed me up long ago. *(pause, a distant look in her eye)* No matter which way I turn, rent ain't never gonna be free.

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AWARDS

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